

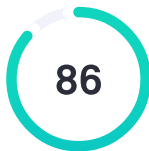
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by Rahul Sharma

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ACS100 - BM

Academic Study Skills – Business Management

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1.0 Introduction

This portfolio looks into both the academic abilities and the employability skills one requires to succeed in higher education, with a particular emphasis on Business Management study. The first of these abilities is the capability to analyse information properly, synthesise ideas, think critically, apply effective citation techniques and use relevant reference formats. Learning these academic concepts greatly contributes towards creating the appropriate atmosphere for enabling my successful academic writing and independent study.

In this portfolio, I will also analyse my own progress in three vital employability skills, namely ICT application, time management and planning, and self-management and self-awareness. The reflective cycle will help me evaluate my academic performance, identify the areas which can be improved, and think of reasonable ways to develop professionally in the future.

2.0 Academic terminologies

2.1 Analysis

According to Cottrell (2024), analysis requires students to evaluate evidence, assess various points of view and defend conclusions using scholarly sources. Analysis is of great importance when it comes to dealing with complex organisational problems instead of merely stating facts. For instance, when evaluating the marketing strategy of a company, an analysis means studying customer behaviour, competitive positioning, and financial performance in order to arrive at some reasonable conclusions (Sintani et al., 2023). This is a practical application of the principle of causation rather than a description of events.

The enhancement of analytical skills also results in an increase in the quality of the decision-making and problem-solving processes. As a result, students are able to identify useful evidence by questioning reliability and building

arguments based on logic. Ultimately, the strength of analysis comes from knowledge-based conclusions rather than an opinion-based assessment.

2.2 Synthesis

Synthesis is an academic skill of obtaining information from various sources and making sense of it. Synthesis is not about discussing an author's viewpoints separately. It includes making connections among the sources in order to understand complex information better (Dahlen et al., 2024).

The process of synthesis is crucial in academic writing when conducting literature reviews and research-based papers. For example, if one is working on the topic of leadership in organisations, the concept of synthesis will allow one to analyse transformational and transactional leadership theories and link them to the research conducted in modern times (Liden et al., 2025). Thus, one will reach conclusions about various approaches to leadership based on academic studies on the issue.

Synthesis is also important in academic writing since it makes arguments stronger by facilitating themes across studies. It enables students to reconcile different opinions, pinpoint areas where further research is needed, and make conclusions based on many authors' works (Schick-Makaroff et al., 2016). Thus, synthesis makes critical thinking inevitable since it means one should act based on their analytical skills and knowledge acquired during the studies.

2.3 Critical Thinking

Critical thinking can be defined as the practice of impartially evaluating evidence, questioning assumptions and reaching conclusions based on solid evidence (Raj et al., 2022). Critical analysis deals with breaking down an issue into its parts, but critical thinking includes students making an evaluation of the evidence before arriving at conclusions. According to Altun and Yildirim (2023), critical thinkers do not just accept claims but use them judiciously.

The concept of critical thinking in Business Management helps learners to analyse differing viewpoints about organisational problems. As an example, a learner addressing the question of whether remote work is advantageous from the perspective of productivity should consider the outcome obtained in various studies, identify differences in the methods used by these studies, and understand what limitations each study poses on the results obtained (Lucia et al., 2025). Students exercise independent judgement and do not depend upon one opinion regarding an issue, so they reach conclusions based on different information sources related to the issue.

Critical thinking makes a contribution to academic integrity by encouraging choices based on research as opposed to biased ones, allowing the absorption of false information, helping in recognising unverifiable statements and formulating convincing arguments based on reliable publications (Machete and Turpin, 2020).

2.4 Referencing

Referencing is considered to be an organised method of crediting all the sources used in the academic paper in order to help the readers track back the origin of ideas and evidence. For instance, the referencing method of Harvard includes the in-text citation and the list of references arranged in alphabetical order (Divecha et al., 2023). Following correct referencing practices proves an author's academic integrity, and readers will be able to check the evidence used to support the argument made.

Using referencing is essential for several reasons apart from preventing plagiarism. It is recognition of intellectual work done by others, adds credibility to academic argumentation, and proves that conclusions are based on trustworthy literature (Neville, 2016). For instance, introducing theories of strategic management into discussion is possible only when giving credit to the

authors and making it clear which information is supported by research and which is the author's opinion.

Effectively developing good referencing skills enhances the quality of research by inculcating in students the habit of engaging with peer-reviewed journals, academic books and reliable business publications (Cottrell, 2024). Thus, consistent application of the Harvard referencing style indicates a high level of professionalism and attention to detail, both of which are required in higher education and business practice.

2.5 Person Formats

"Person formats" refer to the grammatical approach used in academic writing, especially the use of first, second and third person (Li and Ye, 2022). The choice of person influences the tone, objectivity and purpose of writing. For example, third person is recommended in a Business Management assignment, which is formal and objective in style.

Third-person writing eliminates the presence of personal bias since it emphasises the use of facts and data and not the writer (Zhou and Hall, 2016). For example, using the expression "the research shows" in an analytical paper is a more academically suitable option than "I think". The situation is different with reflective portfolios, which imply the use of the first person since the goal is to assess your learning, skills and weaknesses. Phrases such as "I found out about the weak points in my time management" indicate a possibility to reflect properly while retaining the academic structure of the text (Zhou and Hall, 2016).

My awareness of when to use different points of view enhances the written clarity of the work and enables it to fulfil its purpose. Choosing the right perspective allows students to write using the necessary method in analytical papers and portfolios, as well as when preparing official business documents,

thus being an important factor in academic literacy and professional communication.

3.0 Employability skills

3.1 Application of ICT

I discovered my ability to use information and communication technology (ICT) effectively in my academic endeavours upon entering tertiary education. Having gained confidence in various software applications such as Microsoft Word, I am now able to produce academic reports in an appropriate format. I also became familiar with Microsoft PowerPoint and internet-based learning systems. My proficiency in searching academic databases and gathering scholarly resources has ensured that my work is based on relevant evidence. Although I have made progress in developing my digital skills, I understand that I can further enhance my digital skills. In particular, I have almost no experience using Microsoft Excel for quantitative data analysis. To compensate for my shortcomings, I plan to follow an Excel training course and master the creation of tables and graphs (Sartika et al., 2023).

3.2 Time Management and Planning

Despite the improvements made in terms of time management during my studies, I do need to work more on being consistent in this area, as I normally manage to meet assignment deadlines by preparing a weekly study timetable and prioritising my tasks as per submission dates. I have started breaking down tasks into manageable stages that have helped me to feel less under pressure (Patzak et al., 2025).

One of the biggest flaws I have identified in my approach is procrastination of proofreading and editing until the very end of the writing process. This means that I have less time to improve coherence and referencing in my assignments (Patzak et al., 2025). In reflecting on my assignments, I have realised that the

problem is not motivation but simply ineffective milestone planning, as it is necessary to implement SMART planning by assigning each of the stages, i.e., research, writing, editing and referencing, separate deadlines (de Bruin et al., 2023).

3.3 Self-awareness and Self-management

Self-knowledge has been cultivated through the process of receiving feedback from my tutors and reflecting on my academic progress (Görtzen et al., 2025). I've come to understand the importance of scrutinising my own writing instead of assuming that my first draft is the finest writing that I can do. Feedback has highlighted for me recurring weaknesses in writing, such as my ability to conduct thorough analysis and to relate evidence to conclusions (Görtzen et al., 2025). My education requires perseverance and a willingness to be open-minded. Now I see feedback as advice toward my betterment (McGuire, 2025). At the same time, I plan to maintain a reflective journal documenting both my strengths and weaknesses and steps toward my improvement.

4.0 Conclusion

This portfolio illustrates the fact that academia is not merely based on understanding the subject matter. The analysis of process-based skills such as analysing, synthesising, thinking critically, referencing and formatting shows their role in ensuring the quality of academic work. Rather than being independent concepts, the mentioned skills contribute to the quality of arguments and the writing process in academic business management studies. Moreover, the reflective nature of this work shows my own development since I started studying at the higher education level. My confidence in working with digital instruments and planning assignments is paired with the understanding that I still need to improve my editing process and learn from feedback. The ability to set adequate goals in these areas makes the reflection process

practical when every assessment becomes a step toward my personal improvement.

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